

## Share the Road with Trucks (Large trucks and truck-tractor combinations)

Whether you are sharing the road with a passenger car, motorcycle, truck, bus, or other vehicle, it is important to obey traffic laws, abide by the rules of the road, and drive defensively. Trucks are designed to carry products to and from towns and cities; they are designed to be as maneuverable as cars. Trucks have longer stopping and accelerating distances, a wider turning radius, and weigh more.

### Passing

1. When passing a truck, first check to your front and rear, check mirrors and blind spots, then move into the passing lane only if it is clear and you are in a legal passing zone. Let the truck driver know you are passing by flashing your headlights, especially at night. The truck driver should make it easier for you to pass by staying to the far side of the lane.
2. On a level highway, it takes three to five seconds longer to pass a truck than a car. On an upgrade, a truck often loses speed so it's easier to pass than a car. On a downgrade, the truck's momentum causes the truck to go faster so you may need to increase your speed. Complete your pass as quickly as possible and don't stay alongside the other vehicle.
3. If the driver flashes the truck's lights after you pass, it's a signal that it is clear for you to pull back in front of the truck. Be sure to move back only when you can see the entire front of the truck in your rearview mirror. After you pass a truck, maintain your speed.
4. When a truck passes you, help the truck driver by keeping to the far side of your lane. You'll make it easier for the truck driver if you slightly reduce your speed. Don't speed up while the truck is passing. After passing, the truck driver should signal to let you know he is returning to your lane.
5. When you meet a truck coming from the opposite direction, keep as far to the side as possible to avoid a sideswipe crash and to reduce the wind turbulence between the two vehicles. Remember, turbulence pushes vehicles apart; it does not pull them together.

### Following a Truck

1. Tractor-trailers take longer to stop than a car traveling at the same speed. The average passenger car traveling at 55 mph can stop in approximately 240 feet, which is about three-fourths the length of a football field. A fully loaded tractor-trailer may take more than 400 feet to completely stop, well over the length of a football field.
2. If you're following a truck, stay out of its blind spot at the rear. The blind spot is the area behind the truck that the driver cannot see in his rearview mirrors. Avoid following too closely, and position your vehicle so the truck driver can see your vehicle in the truck's side view mirror. An excellent rule of thumb for motorists sharing the road with a tractor-trailer is, "If you can't see the truck driver in his side mirror, he can't see you." By avoiding the truck driver's blind spot, you will have a good view of the road ahead, and the truck driver can give you plenty of warning for a stop or a turn. This will allow you more time to react and make a safe stop.
3. When you follow a truck at night always dim your headlights. Bright lights from a vehicle behind will blind the truck driver when the lights reflect off the truck's large side mirrors.
4. If you are stopped behind a truck on an upgrade, leave space in case the truck drifts back when it starts to move. Also, keep to the left in your lane so the driver can see you're stopped behind the truck.

### Right Turns

Pay attention to turn signals. Trucks make wide, right turns and sometimes leave an open space to the right just before the turn. To avoid a crash, don't pass a truck on the right if there is a possibility the truck might make a right turn.

### Backing Crashes

Never cross behind a truck preparing to back up. When a truck driver is preparing to back the truck from a road into a loading area, the road is temporarily blocked. Wait for the truck to complete its maneuver before trying to pass. If you pass too closely behind the truck, a crash may occur because you are in the truck's blind spot.

### Maneuverability

On multi-lane highways, tractor-trailers stay in the center lane to help the flow of local traffic on and off the highway. Staying in the center lane also increases the truck driver's options if he/she has to switch lanes to avoid a crash. Be aware of common mistakes drivers should avoid when driving around trucks and buses.

### Cutting Off a Vehicle to Reach Your Exit or Turn

Never cut in front of a truck. Cutting into the open space in front of a truck or bus removes the driver's cushion of safety. Trying to beat a truck to a single-lane construction zone represents a particularly dangerous situation. Either slow down and exit or stay behind the truck.